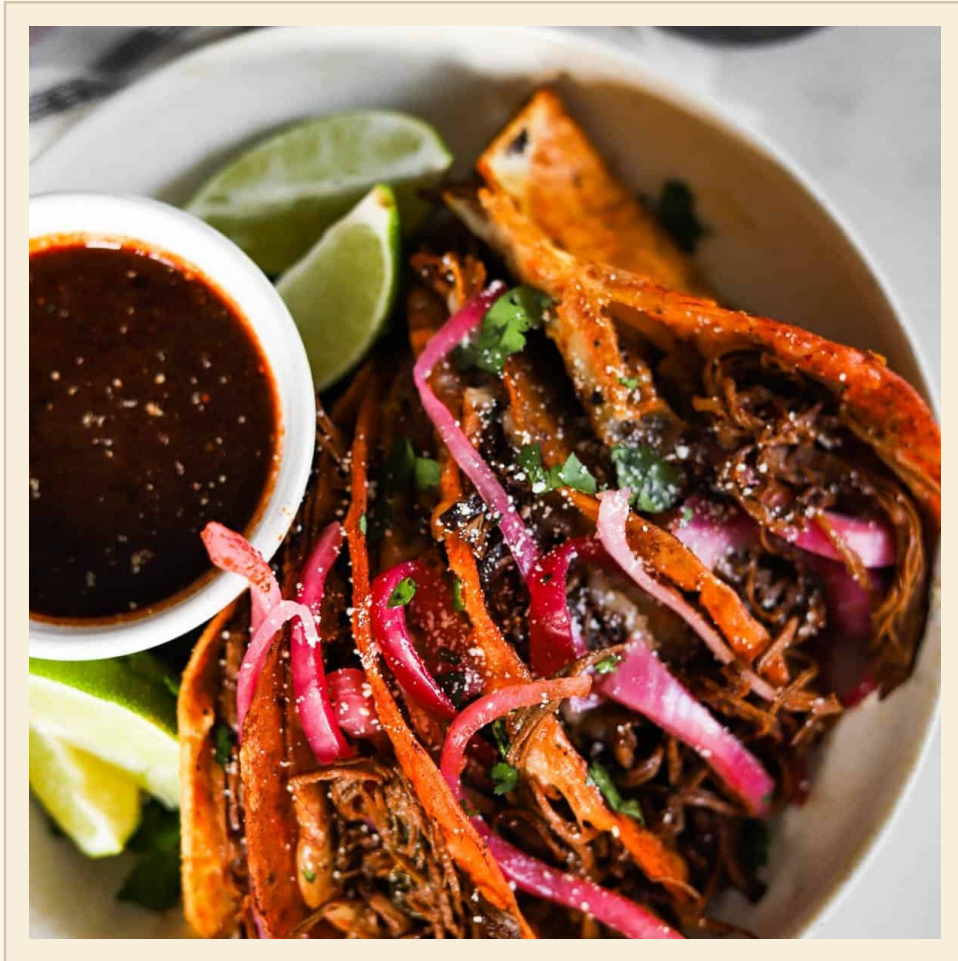


A SHORT, ILLUSTRATED FIELD GUIDE



Tijuana Birria

Red tacos, consomme, and the meat that makes them



THE CUTS - THE CHILES - THE BRAISE - THE TACOS



19 pages - 10 photographs - one very long nap

Contents

		1. What Tijuana birria is (and isn't)	3
		2. The meat: the cuts that matter	4
		3. Chiles, spices and aromatics	6
		4. Where to buy it	8
		5. Equipment	10
		6. Master recipe: birria de res	11
		7. Quesabirria: how to build one	15
		8. Salsa, toppings, sides	16
		9. The day after	17
		10. Troubleshooting	18
		11. Numbers and notes	19

READ THIS FIRST

Birria is a braise, not a race. Everything in this book hangs on three things: **dried chiles you toast** yourself, at least one bone-in cut, **and** salt added at the end, not the start. **Get those right and the rest is negotiable.**

Every recipe is written for **5 lb (2.3 kg) of beef**, which feeds 6-8 people as tacos with consomme, or 4 people with heroic leftovers.



CHAPTER ONE

What Tijuana birria is (and isn't)



Birria was born in Jalisco, and it was born with **goat**. A whole chivo rubbed in chile adobo and slow-cooked until it gives up. Tijuana kept the adobo and changed the animal.

Up north, goat is expensive and hard to get in volume, so Tijuana birrierias went to **beef** - birria de res - built around chuck, shank and bone. Around 2009, the food writer Bill Esparza started seeing that birria folded into tacos at a Tijuana truck called **Tacos Aaron**. Other trucks added cheese. Tijuana taqueros carried the style to Los Angeles around 2016, and Instagram turned it into the most photographed taco on earth.

THE FOUR RULES OF TIJUANA BIRRIA

-  **Beef, in two parts.** One fatty working cut (chuck) plus one bone-in, collagen-heavy cut (shank, oxtail, short rib). The first feeds you; the second makes the consommé.
-  **A guajillo-forward adobo.** Brick red, toasted, tangy with vinegar, warm with canela and clove. It is not smoky and it is not a chipotle braise.
-  **Cooked in its own broth.** Birria makes two products: the meat and the consommé. One without the other is just shredded beef.
-  **Served on a griddled tortilla** dipped in the red fat off the braise, with cheese melted in and a cup of consommé for dunking.

THE THREE THINGS THAT MATTER MOST

- 1. Toast your own chiles.** Pre-ground powder is dull. Twenty seconds in a dry pan is the biggest flavour upgrade available to you.
- 2. Buy bones.** Shank, oxtail, short ribs. Gelatin is what makes the consommé coat a spoon.
- 3. Season at the end.** Reduce, then salt. A braise that tastes right before reducing will taste like seawater after.

CHAPTER TWO

The meat

BIRRIA DE RES

The formula: 60% meaty, fatty cut + 40% bone-in, collagen-heavy cut. The meat is dinner; the bones are the consomme. Buy both.



Bone-in chuck short ribs: fat, marrow and collagen - the three things the pot is built on. Ask for them by the Spanish name and the butcher takes you seriously.

Beef chuck roast

aguja / diezmillo

The backbone of the braise: marbled, collagen-rich, shreds juicy. Buy a whole roast and cut 3-4 in chunks yourself - pre-cut 'stew meat' is a lottery.

WHERE: Cheapest at Costco, Smart & Final, WinCo, Food 4 Less.

Beef shank, cross-cut

chamorro / chambarete

The most important cut for the consomme: rounds about 1.5 in thick, each with a ring of bone and a plug of marrow. Do not skip it.

WHERE: Any carniceria; H-E-B, Northgate, Vallarta, Walmart.

Beef short ribs, bone-in

costillas de res

The splurge: English-cut (thick, on the bone), not flanken. Fat, bone and a deeper, beef-tea flavour.

WHERE: Costco and Sam's, cheap in cryovac packs.

Oxtail

rabo / cola de res

Old-school consomme booster: almost no meat, enormous gelatin. One pound changes the mouthfeel of the whole pot.

WHERE: 99 Ranch, H Mart, Mexican markets (often frozen).

Beef cheeks

cachete de res

What many Tijuana birrierias actually use: silky, collagen-dense, stays moist longer than chuck. You have to ask for it.

WHERE: Carnicerias only: 'Tiene cachete de res?'

Good to excellent, optional

-  **Brisket point (pecho).** Fatty and forgiving; shreds like a dream. The point, not the flat, or it dries out.
-  **Goat (chivo).** The Jalisco original: shoulder and ribs, same adobo, gamier and leaner. Order from a Mexican or Halal butcher a week ahead.
-  **Lamb shoulder (borrego).** The middle road - richer than beef, milder than goat.
-  **Pork shoulder (cerdo).** Not traditional, but birria de puerco has its fans: same adobo, same braise, about three hours. Shoulder or country ribs.
-  **Beef fat trimmings (grasa de res).** Ask for a handful; many carnicerías hand them over. Render them and you have unlimited taco fat.

DO NOT BUY THESE FOR BIRRIA

Pre-cut 'stew meat' - round and trim scraps, cut small; dries out before it tenderises.

Eye of round, top round, rump, sirloin - lean, no collagen, no marrow. Tough at hour one, dry at hour four.

Anything pre-seasoned - you're about to marinate it yourself for eight hours.

How to order it, in Spanish

You need four sentences and a smile. Carnicerías will cut shank to order and save you cheeks if you ask nicely.

"Un trozo de aguja de tres libras, por favor."

A three-pound piece of chuck roast, please.

"Dos libras de chorro, cortado para cocido."

Two pounds of shank, cross-cut for stew.

"Tiene cachete de res?"

Do you have beef cheeks?

"Me regala un poco de grasa de res?"

Could you give me a little beef fat?



CHAPTER THREE

The chiles

CHILE GUAJILLO

Birria is red because of **guajillo**. House ratio: **6 guajillo : 2 ancho : 1 pasilla** plus 3-6 arbol - by weight, 50 / 20 / 10 / 3 g. Weight never lies.



Ancho (dark, wrinkled, raisiny) and guajillo (bright, smooth, tangy) - the two chiles the whole pot is built on.

Guajillo

Thin-walled, glossy, brick red, faintly sour and tea-like. Gives birria its colour and brightness. Flat, brown birria = too little guajillo.

Ancho

A dried poblano: wide, wrinkled, mahogany. Prunes, tobacco, a little cocoa. The roundness and 'stewed-all-day' depth.

Pasilla / chile negro

Long, thin, near-black. Deep and slightly bitter, like dark chocolate. One gives a long finish; three turns medicinal.

Chile de arbol

Small, slender, genuinely hot. Your heat dial and the only one to turn. Three = family. Six = Tijuana truck.

Morita / chipotle

Smoked. One at most, or skip it. Tijuana birria is bright and tangy, not smoky.

BUYING DRIED CHILES LIKE A TAQUERO

They should bend, not snap - brittle chiles are old and taste like paper. Look for glossy pods; smell

the bag: raisins, tea, dried fruit. Nothing smelling like nothing tastes like something.

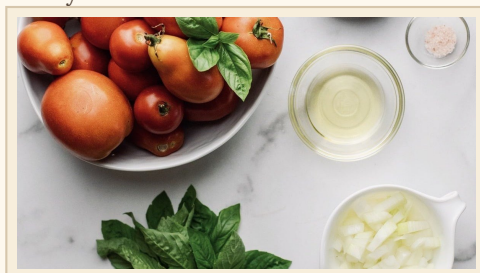
Buy whole, never pre-ground, and by the pound at a Mexican market - a third of the supermarket price and far fresher.

CHAPTER THREE - CONTINUED

Spices and aromatics

CANELA & COMINO

The paste is the voice; these are the backing band. Whole spices get 30-60 seconds in a dry pan until they smell loud.



Fresh aromatics: garlic, onion, tomatoes. / The whole-spice shelf: canela, cloves, peppercorns and more.

Canela (Mexican cinnamon), 1 stick

Softer and more floral than cassia - the background warmth of the pot. Don't leave it out; don't double it.

Whole cloves, 4-6

Clove plus canela is the smell nobody can place. Four is a whisper; ten is mulled wine.

Cumin seed, 1 tsp + peppercorns, 1 tsp, toasted

Birria is cumin-forward, not cumin-dominated - that's the difference between birria and chili.

Mexican oregano, 2 tsp

Not Mediterranean - citrusy, grassy, verbena family. Crush it in your palm.

Dried thyme, 1 tsp + marjoram, 1/2 tsp + 4 bay leaves

The herbal backbone. Bay: two into the paste, two into the pot - fish them out before serving.

Dried ginger, 1/2 tsp

Almost nobody lists it; every good birrieria uses it - the high note that keeps a heavy braise from tasting flat.

Vinegar, 1/4 cup cider or white

The Tijuana signature - the tang that cuts the fat. Into the soak water; a splash more at the end if needed.

THE AROMATICS

- ⊕ **Garlic, 8-10 cloves, unpeeled.** Char until the skins blacken in spots, then peel - charred is sweet, raw is sharp.
- ◎ **White onion, 1.** Half into the paste raw, half diced for topping. Never yellow in the paste - too sweet.
- **Roma tomatoes, 3.** Charred until blistered - body, sweetness, acid. Crushed canned tomato works in a pinch.

CHAPTER FOUR

Where to buy it

EL MERCADO

You can make excellent birria from a single big-box supermarket. You'll make *better, cheaper* birria by buying chiles, bones and tortillas somewhere else. If it isn't out, ask - meat counters cut shank to order almost everywhere.



A carniceria counter is not intimidating once you know four words: *aguja*, *chamorro*, *cachete*, *hueso*.

Big national chains

Costco / Sam's Club

Best price on chuck and short ribs; big bags of guajillo and ancho. No shank, oxtail or cheeks usually.

Walmart

The most complete one-stop: chuck, shank, short ribs, often oxtail, plus chiles, canela and tortillas in the Hispanic aisle.

Kroger family (Ralphs, Fred Meyer, Smith's...)

Strong meat counters, reliable oxtail and short ribs, dried chiles in the international aisle.

Albertsons / Vons / Safeway / Jewel-Osco

Butchers cut the shank; Goya chiles and Oaxaca cheese in many stores.

H-E-B / H-E-B Mi Tienda

The best big-chain birria store in America: in-house carniceria, pre-cut chamorro, oxtail, bulk chiles, own tortilleria.

Smart & Final

Underrated: 10 lb boxes of guajillo, cryovac chuck, oxtail, canela by the sleeve. Where small taquerias shop.

WinCo / Food 4 Less / Save A Lot

Cheapest chuck, onion and garlic; WinCo's bulk bins sell spices for pennies. Thin on chiles.

Trader Joe's / Sprouts / Whole Foods / Publix / Target

TJ's and Target have no butcher counter but good tortillas, cheese and chiles; Sprouts, Whole Foods and Publix have great meat and spice bins, pricey chiles, special orders.

Mexican and Latino markets: go if you have one

This is where birria actually gets bought. Chiles by the pound at a third of the price, shank already cross-cut, oxtail, cachete, free beef fat, tortillas made that morning.

 **Northgate Market** (CA, TX): full carniceria, great chile wall, tortilleria in store.

 **Vallarta, El Super, Cardenas, Superior Grocers, La Michoacana** (CA, NV, AZ, TX): the standard Southern California birria run.

 **Fiesta Mart** (TX), **Sedano's** (FL), **Bravo, Compare Foods**: same idea, different coasts.

 **99 Ranch, H Mart, Zion and other Asian markets**: the best oxtail in town - cheaper, thicker-cut, usually fresh not frozen.

Cheese and tortillas

 **Queso Oaxaca (quesillo)**: the ideal - stringy, mild, browns beautifully. Any Mexican market; most big chains now.

 **Queso Chihuahua / menonita**: the northern alternative. Melts smoother, browns slower.

 **Low-moisture whole-milk mozzarella**: what half the LA trucks actually use. Buy the block and shred it yourself - pre-shredded is coated in cellulose and will not stretch.

 **Corn tortillas, taquera size (about 5 in)**, from a tortilleria if possible. Guerrero, Mission, La Banderita and El Milagro are the reliable bags. Warm the stack or they crack.

Online, if there's nothing nearby

Dried chiles travel well and keep for months. Goya, Don Enrique and El Mexicano bags are on Amazon; MexGrocer and Zocalo Foods are the specialist grocers - a genuinely good route for guajillo, ancho, pasilla and canela.



CHAPTER FIVE

Equipment

LA COCINA

You need one heavy pot and a blender - a \$60 enameled Lodge will outlive you. Everything else is a convenience.



One heavy, tight-lidded pot does most of the work.

ESSENTIAL

7-8 quart Dutch oven, tight lid. Heavy is the whole point; a thin pot scorches the paste in the last hour.

Blender - a \$30 one is fine, you're straining the paste anyway.

Fine-mesh strainer - non-negotiable: the difference between silky restaurant consomme and gritty home braise.

A comal, cast-iron skillet or wide pan for toasting and griddling - a comal is about \$15 - plus tongs and two forks.

NICE TO HAVE

Pressure cooker / Instant Pot. 45 minutes instead of 3.5 hours, texture just as good - the best shortcut in this book.

Slow cooker. 8-9 hours on low; boil the consomme down 15 minutes at the end.

Digital scale, fat separator, mortar and pestle - scale for chiles and salt, separator for the fat cap.

TIMING, BY METHOD (5 LB OF MEAT)

Pressure cooker		45 min
Oven, 300 F		3 - 3.5 hr
Stovetop, low		3.5 - 4 hr
Slow cooker, low		8 - 9 hr

Unattended cook time only. Add 30 minutes of prep and 20 of finishing to every method.

CHAPTER SIX

Birria de res

LA RECETA

Yield: 12-16 quesabirrias plus about 8 cups of consommé. **Active time:** 45 minutes. **Braise:** 3.5-4 hours (or 45 minutes under pressure). **Marinate:** 4 hours to overnight. **Feeds:** 6-8.

 THE MEAT

Chuck roast (aguja), in 3-4 in chunks	3 lb	Whole cloves	4-6
Beef shank, cross-cut 1.5 in (chamorro)	1.5 lb	Cumin seed / peppercorns	1 tsp each
Bone-in short ribs or oxtail	1 lb	Mexican oregano	2 tsp

 THE CHILES

Guajillo, stemmed and seeded	6	Dried thyme + marjoram	1 + 1/2 tsp
Ancho, stemmed and seeded	2	Dried ginger	1/2 tsp
Pasilla, stemmed and seeded	1	Bay leaves	4
Chile de arbol, to taste	3-6	Vinegar, cider or white	1/4 cup
		Kosher salt, plus more at the end	1 tbsp

 AROMATICS AND SPICES

Garlic cloves, unpeeled	8-10	 TO FINISH AND SERVE	
Roma tomatoes	3	Queso Oaxaca or mozzarella block	1 lb
White onion	1	Corn tortillas, taquera size	2 dozen
Canela (Mexican cinnamon)	1 stick	Onion and cilantro, chopped	
		Limes + salsa de arbol (p. 16)	

 HOW TO READ THIS RECIPE

Four pages: the shopping list (this page), the chile paste, marinate and braise, consommé and shred. The paste can be made a day ahead. Total time from nothing to tacos: about 5 hours, most of it unattended.



CHAPTER SIX - STEP ONE

The chile paste

EL ADOBO

Thirty minutes of work, ninety percent of the flavour. Do it the night before to split the job in two.



Toast until fragrant and pliable - never smoking. / Then soak 25-30 minutes in hot water and vinegar.

1 Clean the chiles

Snap off the stems, split each chile down one side, shake out the seeds and pull out the pale veins. **The veins hold most of the heat** - all out for mild, a few left in for a truck bite.

2 Toast them

Dry comal over **medium**. Press each chile flat for **20-30 seconds a side** until it smells like raisins and warm bread. The moment you see smoke or a black blister, it's burnt and the pot will be bitter - throw it out and start again.

3 Soak them

Cover the chiles with **2 cups of very hot (not boiling) water** and the **1/4 cup vinegar**, weight with a plate, soak **25-30 minutes** until completely soft. Keep the soaking liquid.

4 Char the aromatics

On the same comal, blister the **tomatoes** and **unpeeled garlic** until blackened in spots and slumping, 8-10 minutes. Peel the garlic; toast the **cumin** for 30 seconds alongside.

5 Blend it smooth

Blender: drained chiles, charred tomatoes and garlic, **1 cup soaking liquid**, half the onion, the cumin, peppercorns, cloves, canela, oregano, thyme, marjoram, ginger, 2 bay leaves, **1 tbsp salt**. Blend on high a full **2-3 minutes** - a gritty paste stays gritty.

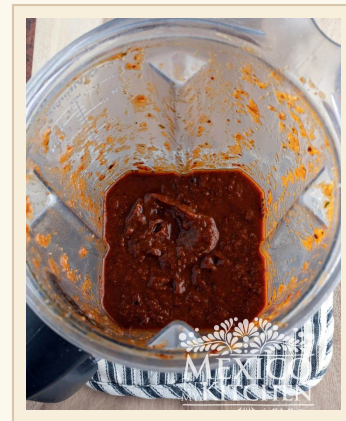
6 Strain it

Push the paste through a **fine-mesh strainer**, working it with a ladle. Skins, seeds and fibres stay behind. This feels fussy and it is the whole difference between home birria and taqueria birria.

CHAPTER SIX - STEPS TWO AND THREE

Marinate, then braise

EL REMOJO



The finished paste: thick, glossy, brick red.

STEP TWO: MARINATE (10 min + 4 hours to overnight)

7 Coat the meat

Pat the meat dry, season with the **1 tbsp salt**, and toss with the strained paste until every piece is heavily coated. Refrigerate **at least 4 hours**, ideally overnight, up to 24.

STEP THREE: BRAISE (3.5 to 4 hours)

8 Sear, if you have the patience

Brown the meat in batches in a little oil, 2 minutes a side, without crowding. Optional, but it adds a roasted depth you can taste. Skip it in a slow cooker.

9 Build the pot

Leftover marinade into the pot with the rest of the soaking liquid plus enough **water or broth to come three-quarters up the meat** (about 4 cups). Do not submerge it. Add the remaining bay leaves and every bone you have.

10 Cook it

Boil, skim the grey foam, cover tightly, then: **oven 300 F, 3-3.5 hr / stovetop, lowest simmer, 3.5-4 hr / pressure 45 min + 15 min release / slow cooker, low, 8-9 hr**. The liquid should barely tremble, never bubble hard.

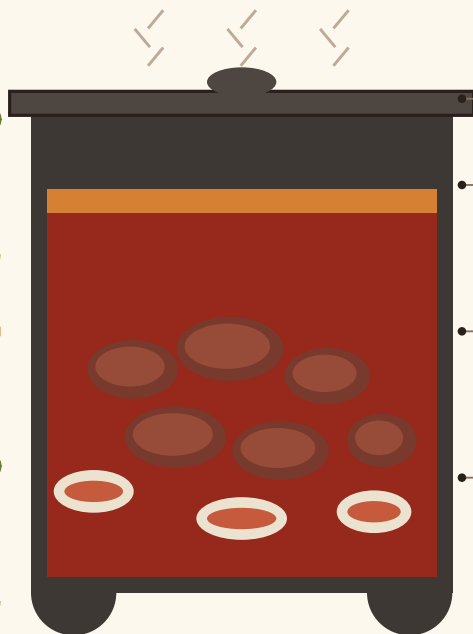
11 Know when it's done

A fork slides into the thickest piece with **zero resistance**. Temperature is not the test - **collagen melts at 180-195 F and needs *time* there**, not just arrival. Still firm means another 30 minutes, not more heat.

CHAPTER SIX - STEP FOUR

Consomme and shred

EL CONSOMMÉ



• **Fat cap** — the red-orange oil that rises. Skim it; this is what you griddle the tortillas in.

• **Consomme** — the broth. Season it boldly; it gets drunk as much as sipped.

• **Meat** — 3/4 submerged so the top browns and concentrates.

• **Bones** — shank, oxtail or short rib. Gelatin = body.

What you're looking at when you lift the lid: a fat cap you want, a consommé you must season, and bones that did their job.

12 Lift out the meat

Meat out with tongs; discard the bones, bay leaves and cinnamon stick. Shred with two forks - **shredded but not stringy**, stop while it still has body. Or chop it roughly, like a lot of trucks do.

13 Skim the fat - and keep it

Let the broth settle 5 minutes, then ladle the **red-orange fat** into a bowl. This is the taco fat - what you dip the tortillas in. A 5 lb pot gives you 1/2 to 3/4 cup.

14 Season the consommé hard

It should be savoury, tangy and slightly **too salty** on its own, because a tortilla is about to soak it up. Fix in this order: **salt**, then a splash of **vinegar**, then half a **bouillon cube** or 1/2 tsp **MSG** if it tastes hollow. Thin? Boil it down 10-15 minutes.

15 Crisp the meat before serving

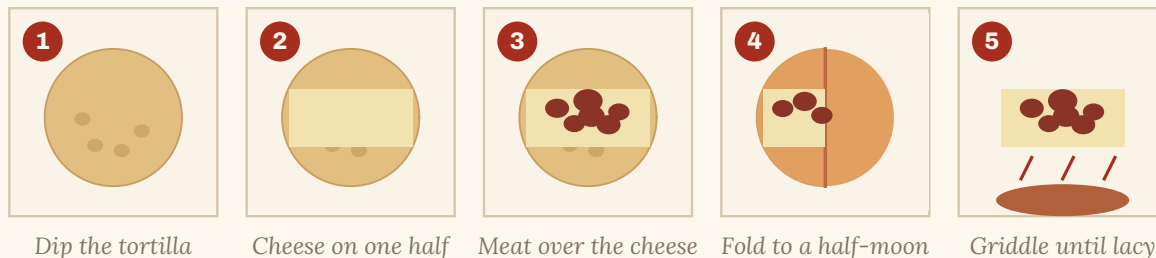
Keep meat and consommé separately. Right before eating, crisp the shredded meat in a hot pan with a ladle of the reserved fat until the edges catch - 3-4 minutes. This is the step that separates quesabirria from a bowl of stew.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Quesabirria

QUESABIRRIA

A taco that went to quesadilla school: tortilla dipped in red fat, cheese, meat, folded, griddled until lacy and brick-coloured, consomme on the side for dunking.



The sequence, start to finish. All five panels happen in about ninety seconds per taco.

Build it

- 1 Heat the plancha**
 Comal or wide skillet over **medium-high** with 2-3 tbsp of the reserved red fat. Not maximum - there's sugar in that chile paste and it will scorch.
- 2 Dip the tortilla**
 Drag a corn tortilla through the hot fat (or across the top of the consomme pot) so both sides stain red. One second a side. Lay it flat on the plancha.
- 3 Cheese, then meat**
 A generous handful of shredded **Oaxaca or mozzarella** (2-3 oz) on **one half**, then a big spoonful of crisped meat on top. Cheese down, meat up - the cheese against the tortilla is the glue.
- 4 Fold and griddle**
 Fold into a half-moon, press down, and cook **1-2 minutes** until the underside is deep red-brown and lacy at the edges. Flip, one more minute. You want audible crisping.
- 5 Serve it in ninety seconds**
 Straight to the plate with a cup of hot consomme, plus chopped onion, cilantro, lime and salsa on the table. These do not hold - cook and eat in batches.

CHAPTER SEVEN - CONTINUED

Salsa, toppings, sides

SALSA DE ÁRBOL

FIVE THINGS THAT GO WRONG

Tortillas cracking: cold or too thin. Warm the stack in a towel first; buy taquera-size.

Nothing sticks together: not enough cheese, or it's pre-shredded. Buy the block.

Burnt outside, cold inside: heat too high - medium, 30 more seconds a side.

Soggy, not crispy: the dip was a soak, or the pan wasn't hot enough.

Not red enough: thin fat cap or thin chile paste - more paste in the pan next time.

Salsa de chile de arbol

The one you actually want on a quesabirria: thin, sharp, hot, ten minutes. **8 arbol, stemmed - 2 husked tomatillos - 1 garlic clove, unpeeled - 1 tbsp vinegar - 1/2 tsp salt.**

Toast the chiles **30 seconds a side** - don't let them blacken or it turns bitter. Char the tomatillos and garlic until blistered, 5 minutes. Blend with 1/2 cup hot water, the vinegar and salt until smooth, then thin until it pours like heavy cream. Keeps a week and gets hotter on day two.

The plate, minus the taco

Onion and cilantro, chopped fine and mixed together. Not a garnish - a requirement.

Lime wedges. Birria is rich; acid is not optional.

Pickled onions - slice one thin, cover with the juice of 3 limes and a pinch of salt, wait 30 minutes. Or the classic jarred escabeche of carrots, onion and jalapeno.

A cup of consomme for every person, topped with onion, cilantro and lime. This is the whole point.

To drink: horchata, jamaica, a Mexican Coke in the bottle, or a cold lager with lime in the neck.

HOW TO EAT ONE WITHOUT EMBARRASSMENT

Hold it over the consomme. Dunk a corner, bite, dunk again. Crisp at the edges, soft where the broth got in. If cheese escapes, you have done it correctly.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The day after

SOBRAN TACOS

Make a double batch. Birria is at its best on day two, and the consomme is the most useful thing in your freezer.

Birria ramen

The reason to double the recipe. Bring **2 cups of consomme** to a boil, drop in fresh ramen noodles, finish with shredded birria, corn, a soft-boiled egg, onion, cilantro, lime and a spoonful of salsa de arbol. Not traditional; completely correct.

Mulitas

The quesabirria's simpler cousin: **two** tortillas, cheese and meat sandwiched between them, griddled in red fat, cut into quarters. More cheese-to-meat contact; structurally superior.

Vampiros

Spread a **tostada** with red fat, crisp it on the comal, pile on cheese, meat, onion, cilantro, salsa and lime.

Chilaquiles rojos de birria

Fry quartered tortillas until crisp, simmer in **consomme** for 2 minutes until half-soft, top with birria, crema, queso fresco and a fried egg. The best breakfast in this book.

Torta ahogada, birria style

Split a **bolillo**, spread with refried beans, fill with birria and Oaxaca, and ladle hot consomme over the top. Eat it over a bowl with a fork and no dignity.

Consomme, on its own

A mug with onion, cilantro, lime and a handful of meat is a legitimate meal - it's what half of Tijuana orders at 7 a.m. Freeze it in **ice cube trays** and you have instant flavour for rice, beans and soups for three months.

STORAGE

Fridge: meat and consomme separately, up to 4 days. The consomme sets into jelly when cold - that's the collagen, and it means you did it right.

Freezer: meat with a ladle of broth, 3 months. Consomme in pint containers - plus ice cube trays for emergencies.



CHAPTER NINE

Troubleshooting

¡ÁNIMO!

It tastes bitter

WHY: You burnt the chiles - even a few seconds of smoke does it.

This batch: a teaspoon of sugar and a knob of butter, and a raw potato in the pot for 20 minutes.

Next time: cooler pan, shorter toast, pull at the first smell of raisins.

The consomme is gritty

WHY: The paste wasn't strained, or the blender didn't run long enough.

Strain the consomme itself through a fine sieve into a clean pot. Next time: 3 minutes in the blender, then strain, no excuses.

It tastes flat and dull

WHY: Usually under-salted, usually also missing acid.

Salt first, a teaspoon at a time, tasting between. Then a splash of vinegar or lime. Then half a bouillon cube or 1/2 tsp MSG. Salt and acid, in that order, fix almost everything.

The meat is dry and stringy

WHY: The cut was too lean, or it isn't actually done yet.

'Dry' at hour three often means 'tight' - keep cooking, submerged, another 30-45 minutes; collagen needs time, not just heat. Next time: chuck plus bones, and never the round.

The consomme is thin

WHY: Too much water, or no bones in the pot.

Boil it down uncovered 10-20 minutes until it coats a spoon. Next time: shank or oxtail, and fill only three-quarters up the meat.

Way too spicy

WHY: Arbol chiles, or you left the veins in.

Stir in crema or butter per portion and serve with more lime. Next time: all veins out, 2 arbol.

The cheese won't stretch

WHY: Pre-shredded cheese, or too dry a cheese.

Buy Oaxaca or a block of low-moisture whole-milk mozzarella and shred it yourself. Pre-shredded is dusted in starch so it won't clump - or melt.

It smells like a barbecue

WHY: Too much chipotle or morita.

You've made a different, also-delicious thing. Next time: one morita at most. Tijuana birria is bright and tangy, not smoky.

CHAPTER TEN

Numbers and notes

NOTAS

Temperatures: 300 F / 150 C for the braise; collagen melts into gelatin at an internal 180-195 F / 82-90 C; 165 F is where most people panic, pull the meat, and ruin dinner. Keep going.

Weights: 1 lb = 454 g, 1 cup = 240 ml, 1 tbsp = 15 ml, 1 tsp = 5 ml. The 5 lb (2.3 kg) this book is built around: **3 lb chuck + 1.5 lb shank + 1 lb short rib or oxtail**. Chiles: **50 g guajillo, 20 g ancho, 10 g pasilla, 3 g arbol**.

Cheat sheet, one page

PIN THIS TO THE FRIDGE

Meat: 3 lb chuck + 1.5 lb cross-cut shank + 1 lb short rib or oxtail.

Chiles: 6 guajillo, 2 ancho, 1 pasilla, 3-6 arbol. Toast, soak 30 min, blend 3 min, strain.

Spice: canela, 4 cloves, 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp pepper, 2 tsp Mexican oregano, 1 tsp thyme, 1/2 tsp marjoram, 1/2 tsp ginger, 4 bay, 1/4 cup vinegar, 1 tbsp salt.

Cook: 300 F covered, 3.5 hr (or 45 min at pressure). Liquid three-quarters up the meat.

Finish: skim the red fat, shred, season the consomme with salt then vinegar, crisp the meat in the fat.

Serve: dip tortilla in fat, cheese down, meat up, fold, griddle 2 min, consomme on the side.

Your birria, your numbers

Write it down the moment you nail it, because you will not remember in three months.

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Cook it for people. Make twice as much as you think you need. Keep the consomme.

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